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los angeles - Assembly member, port leaders ask for $1 billion in funding

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Assemblymember Mike Gipson, D-Carson, and Port of Los Angeles leaders called for the state government to support the 11 California deep-water ports and supply chain readiness needs by including $1 billion for a coordinated investment strategy in the fiscal year 2027 budget.

Emphasizing global suppliers' need for predictable and sustained investments, Gipson and Los Angeles County partners convened stakeholders at the Los Angeles Harbor on Friday overlooking the San Pedro Bay.

"Today I urge California to step up to the import and export challenges of our time and make a significant 2027 spending commitment to ports, including five investment categories," said Gipson, who also chairs the Select Committee on Ports and Goods Movement. "Activities at ports like the Port of Los Angeles in my assembly district support 3.1 million jobs, generate $134 billion in worker income and add $38 billion in tax revenue.

"Lately, however, the competitiveness of our cities and state sits at risk, especially without more vital tools to assist in modernization," Gipson added. "I am glad to have my budget letter supported by seven of my colleagues on the Select Committee on Ports and Goods Movement, as well as the California Association of Port Authorities."

With federal funding being uncertain and the continued impact of tariffs, Gipson called on state leaders to step up to help modernize the ports and create local jobs to ensure California's ports stay competitive nationally and internationally. The $1 billion allocation ask is backed by port leaders and stakeholders as well.

On Friday, Gipson was joined by Port of Los Angeles Executive Director Gene Seroka; Port of Long Beach CEO Noel Hacegaba, who serves as president of the California Association of Port Authorities; International Longshore and Warehouse Union Local 13 President Gary Herrera; and other CAPA representatives and stakeholders from Los Angeles' harbor region.

"California's ports are essential gateways for global trade and major economic engines for our state," Seroka said. "Strategic investments in infrastructure and modernization will help our ports handle growing cargo volume, deploy new sustainable technologies and sustain the high-quality jobs that support communities across California."

Hacegaba shared similar sentiments of California's ports being vital to the state economy, the nation's transportation system and the global supply chain.

"As geopolitical and trade tensions reshape the global supply chain, it's more important than ever to make California's ports more efficient, reliable and resilient," Hacegaba said. "We are grateful to Assemblymember Gipson for leading this effort to ensure California's ports have the resources necessary to grow our economic impact and support more good-paying jobs as we continue to lead the transition to zero emission operations."

ILWU Local 13 also recognizes the importance of infrastructure improvement, Herrera said, but not at the cost of jobs. And this legislation, he said, asks the state to make zero-emission, human-operated equipment possible.

"On behalf of our approximately 60,000 members and dependents, we applaud Assemblymember Gipson for his vision in advocating for this critical investment, which emphasizes a balance between economic justice and environmental justice, and we strongly encourage the rest of our leaders in the California Legislature to do the same," Herrera said. "Future development that promotes the growth of cargo volumes and jobs in the ports while eliminating pollution for neighboring communities is a triple win."

A coalition of advocates who see the need for strategic investments plans to ensure that California's deep-water economic engines are not overlooked by engaging leaders in the Legislature — including Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, and Assemblymember Steve Bennett, D-Oxnard, chairs of the Assembly Budget Committee and the Subcommittee No. 4, respectively, according to a news release.

"Every day, as opportunities and challenges alike arise overseas, I see no infrastructure need more important to a state that holds the world's fourth-largest economy than an investment in our ports," Gipson said. "They open for business to every business, but they need us. Across our economy, it's clear what Sacramento can do to advance the work the ports do, and I call on my colleagues to make this year's budget a transformative one for California's port leaders and workers."

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